In Elementum

1. Game Description/Summary

In Elementum is a turn-based RPG/2D-platformer. Think of it as a combination of *Hollow Knight* and *Claire-Obscure: Expedition 33*. Players control seven characters that utilize different elements (fire, water, wind, lightning, earth, dark, and light) to manipulate the environment during exploration and to combine their powers in battle.

2. Target Audience/Platform

The game will target a teen-and-up audience. In general, it should be appealing to any age group, but due to certain complex themes discussed by characters and the nature of fantasy violence, it'll likely appeal more towards adolescents and older. For platforms, ideally, this game would be available all across the board, but there should be priority to release on PC and the Nintendo Switch. Those platforms are more indie-game friendly, and *In Elementum* would be similar to games already released there (ex: *Hollow Knight*, *Ender Lillies*, *Child of Light*). Since the game is a 2D platformer during exploration, UI elements should be kept to a minimum to allow players to get an extensive view of the environment. The UI would only pop up when opening the menu or switching between controllable characters, and there is also a button prompt indicating a special interaction a certain character can perform. Switching would be a quick menu pop-up like a radial wheel, and characters are selectable through icons representing them.

During battle, the UI is more detailed to show character health, character ability points, enemy health, Special Attack Gauge, and turn order. When it's a character's turn, a side menu will pop up to give the players choices between actions (attack, ability, item). When it's an enemy's turn, there will be prompts given by the players to dodge or parry enemy attacks.

3. Game Story and Characters

The game starts with a short introductory cutscene describing the world *In Elementum* takes place in. To give a brief run-down, the Earth as we know it had been divided into seven elemental realms due to a catastrophic event. Millennia later, civilizations had developed, built by the people who now harness the elemental powers of the realm they live in. Due to being physically divided across space, peace is maintained to share resources, although natural differences between the elements make that difficult, and tensions remain high.

At the start of the main story, an unknown catastrophe begins, causing elemental energy between the realms to fluctuate uncontrollably and having disastrous effects on the realms and their people. Overwhelmed by the influx of power, many citizens have transformed into monsters. Not only that, but there seems to be a realm-wide crossover, exposing divided elements to each other's lands for the worse. Our main protagonist, Princess Illumine, awakens to this disaster and is immediately escorted by a guard to an emergency exit.

After Illumine reaches the exit, she finds herself in the Medium, a pocket-realm not usually accessible, where all the elements are able to exist freely without risk of endangering themselves. She quickly meets six other individuals who had also escaped into the Medium. With their realms facing a shared disaster, it’s time for unity as they must work together to figure out the cause of this catastrophe and put a stop to it.



*concept art I made of the playable characters

I. Playable Characters

- Illumine: An elemental of light and princess of her realm. A benevolent but determined leader, Illumine doesn't let her royal status keep her from using any means she deems necessary to accomplish a goal.
- Phoenix: A fire elemental who is the heir of the Ignis Empire. Phoenix, though a little brash, wields his flames with discipline and tries to maintain a free-spirited heart.
- Kaimana: A water elemental who is regarded as the High Priestess of their temple. While they may have a calm exterior, there seems to be a much murkier, colder side of Kaimana's heart that they try to keep under wraps.
- Zephyr: A wind elemental and formerly a part of the esteemed Caenum Clan. Sharpened by his life of solitude after banishment, Zephyr doesn't let the right opportunities go to waste.
- Elec: A lightning elemental with a knack for engineering. Despite her inventions usually being disapproved of by her people, Elec never let her inventive spirit falter, which manifests as a thrill-seeking personality.
- Terra: An earth elemental who is a retired warrior. Terra's optimistic attitude keeps her steadfast as she finds the will to fight for her realm once more.
- Diasas: A darkness elemental and recently crowned king of his realm. Diasas's harsh, strict upbringing has made him a closed-off individual, though he does long for closer connections with his peers.

II. Non-playable Characters

- Bouldy: An earth elemental who is a blacksmith-in-training. Although officially recognized as an apprentice, he puts much effort into making sure every weapon and piece of armor is in top condition.

- Astrid: A fire elemental who is the head chef of the Ignis Palace. As long as there's something edible within reach, she will somehow make a great meal out of it.
- Merchant Guild Representatives: Merchants who are a part of a cross-realm guild. They think the current chaos brings good business. Give them currency upon encountering them and they will be willing to trade for a good piece of equipment and items.

4. Gameplay and Interaction

a. Exploration

In exploration, the gameplay takes elements from the 2D-platformer/metroidvania genre (ex: *Hollow Knight*, *Metroid*). There are three primary actions the player can do within exploration.

- Move right and left along the screen
- Jump onto platforms for vertical movement
- Interact with certain prompts in the environment

The interact action can do multiple things. If the button prompt to interact appears while exploring the player can:

- Collect *resources
- Rest at a save point
- Do a special exploration action that is specific to the current controlled character
- Attack an enemy to initiate combat
- Initiate conversation with an NPC

*Resources include health restoration items, ingredients for cooking at camp, materials for upgrading equipment, currency to exchange for new items at merchants

The player can switch control between all playable characters during exploration (only the playable character is visible while in control). All playable characters are able to do the three

primary actions as described earlier. Each character has a unique exploration action that can be used if the player recognizes an opportunity to use it. The exploration actions are as follows:

- Illumine: can summon an orb of light (illuminates dark areas and can also act as a marker for exploration)
- Phoenix: burn flammable objects that are blocking the path (flammable objects are highlighted in red if Phoenix is currently controlled)
- Kaimana: fill gaps in the ground with water (while in water, can move up, down, left, and right throughout the screen)
- Zephyr: after holding the interact button down for three seconds, will perform a straight vertical jump
- Elec: after holding the interact button down for three seconds, will perform a straight horizontal dash
- Terra: if there are cracks in the ground, can destroy it
- Diasas: if there are shadows highlighting an area, can travel through or jump from shadow to shadow

While exploring, the player can also find chests. Chests are containers holding special items or materials. Chests have three different designs depending on its contents.

- Brown chests hold regular materials like currency or upgrade materials
- Golden chests hold rare equipment (armor, weapons, accessories)
- Silver chests hold key items for quests or level progression

The player can find checkpoints at different points of a level. If a plyaer rests at a checkpoint, the party's health will be fully restored and a menu will pop up. The player will then have a few options available for them.

- Save Progress
- Teleport: teleport to any checkpoint in the level
- Skill Trees: use experience points to unlocok new abilities
- Return to Medium: automatically return to the Medium

While exploring, enemies will roam certain parts of the map. Enemies will not immediately attack players until they are aggroed(aggroed state is activated if player is in line of sight of the enemy). If aggroed, enemies will chase after the player. If an enemy attacks the player and the attack hits, combat is initiated, and the first turn goes to the enemy. If the player, however, attacks first and hits the enemy, combat is initiated, and the first turn goes to the player.

b. Combat

In combat, gameplay switches into a turn-based RPG (ex: *Final Fantasy*, *Persona*). The player's party of controllable characters is comprised of four members. Combat party members can be set manually by the player from the main menu. This party is not affected by who the player is controlling during exploration. Turn order is determined by a) if the player or the enemy had initiated combat b) the average speed of the party c) the speed stat of the party member.

I. Stats

Every character has five stats that determine their strength in battle. The more points allocated into a stat, the higher the effectiveness of that stat in battle.

- Vitality: determines the number of health points a character has
- Defense: determines how much damage a character takes if hit by an enemy
- Strength: determines how much damage a character deals through attacks and abilities on an enemy
- Speed: determines how often a character takes a turn in battle

- Luck: determines a character's chance to inflict critical damage (critical damage is extra damage dealt by attacks and certain abilities)

II. Player turn

There are four actions the player can take. Every party member can take these actions.

- Attack: basic attack on the enemy
    - Attacking is a single hit that deals damage on an enemy. Every hit through attacking grants an ability point (AP). The number of hits while attacking can be increased based on the character's equipment (weapon and accessories).
- Ability: use an ability
    - Every party member has a unique set of abilities. Abilities have various effects and functions (ex: deal damage, buff party members, set status effects). Abilities require AP to be used. Each ability has a varying amount of AP required to be used. The effectiveness of an ability can be boosted if the player succeeds a quick time event that pops up right as the character performs the action.
- Item: use an item
    - Items can restore health points or ability points. There is also an item that can revive dead party members. Items are shared between all party members.
- Surge: activate an elemental surge
    - Surge is a special attack that can deal an immense amount of damage to the enemy or grant a powerful buff to party members. To activate an

elemental surge, the player must first fill the Surge Gauge (fills incrementally with every successful attack and parry). Each party member has one unique surge. There are also Fusion Surges that are performed by two party members who have a sufficient relationship with one another. A fusion surge can be activated as long as at least one out of the two party members is active in combat, and it is that character's turn. Surges and Fusion Surges are unlocked throughout the game at different points (either through the main story or side content).

Players are only allowed one action per turn. Players have the choice to skip a turn if they deem it appropriate to do so.

II. Enemy Turn

Enemies can either be individuals or a team. Each enemy has their own turn and can also take only one action within that turn. Actions include attacking the party, placing a status effect on the party, and buffing themselves. When an enemy attacks, there will be a QTE that appears. The player can take two actions upon seeing the QTE:

- Dodge: dodge and avoid taking any damage
- Parry: deflect an attack and gain AP upon each successful parry. Take damage if fail the QTE.

Dodging and parrying can be performed interchangeably for each QTE prompt. These offer choices for the player in how to defend themselves (dodging is safer to avoid damage, while parrying is riskier but reaps reweards). Every attack can be dodged or parried. Sometimes an enemy will perform a Perilous Attack. A perilous attack does even more damage to party members than regular attacks and is signaled by a red glow emanating from the enemy right

before attacking. If a player succeeds in parrying against a perilous attack, the party will perform a counterattack and deal damage to the enemy equivalent to what would have been dealt to the party.

III. Defeat

If a party member's health reaches 0, that party member will be incapacitated and will no longer participate in the remainder of the battle unless another party member uses certain items or abilities on their turn to resurrect them. If every party member's health reaches 0, there will be an opportunity to Call Backup.

Call Backup: the remaining three party members not in the active party will replace the currently incapacitated party. Items not used by the active party will transfer to the backup. Progress of the Surge Bar resets upon calling backup.

If every party member in the backup reaches 0 health points, then the player will be defeated. Upon defeat, the player will be given the choice to either restart the battle or respawn at the last checkpoint they arrived at prior to the start of the battle.

IV. Victory

If at least one party member has health points remaining and the enemy/enemies have reached 0 health points, then the player has achieved victory in the battle. The player will be rewarded with experience points, resources for cooking or upgrading material, and even special equipment if the defeated enemy was a boss. Every enemy will drop different rewards for the player.

The Medium

The Medium acts as a hub world and campsite for the player. There is no exploration or combat possible in the Medium. All player choices are presented through a menu that overlays various scenes of the playable characters interacting with each other.

- Cook: Astrid can cook a meal for the party with materials found while exploring
    - Meals give certain stat bonuses to characters. If a character favors the meal, they get a special condition while in active combat, where they take less damage from enemies.
    - The player is free to pick any ingredients they want for meals, as they will have to discover recipes themselves. Meals are recorded into a recipe after the player cooks.
- Upgrade Equipment: Bouldy can upgrade the weapon and armor of the party with materials found while exploring
    - There is a limited number of unique weapons and armor for every character in the game. The more upgrades invested into a weapon, the higher the damage while attacking or using an offensive ability. Armor upgrades will increase the amount of bonus defense a character receives. Upgrades to armor and weapons will also unlock passive abilities that are activated as long as that character is wielding/wearing that piece of equipment.
- Camp Tasks: Assign duo and individual chores for the party to do around camp
    - Duo chores will significantly boost the relationship between the two characters that are assigned to the chore.
    - Individual chores will moderately boost the relationship between the single character and every party member.

    - Chores can only be done once per rest at the Medium.
- Party Relations: Check the relationship status between the playable characters
    - There are five levels of relationship between every playable character. Characters gain relationship levels with one another by doing chores or by performing in active combat together.
    - At level 2, 3, and 5 of a relationship, a special cutscene will play showing a unique interaction between the two characters who have reached that point. These cutscenes are optional and won't play unless the player wishes to view them.
    - Reaching level three of a relationship unlocks a unique ability for both characters that can be used in combat.
    - Reaching level 5 unlocks the characters' Fusion Surge.

The cutscenes that play when observing the party relations are the primary way for players to get to know the characters on a deeper level outside of the main story. As one of the main themes of this game is unity, it's important to see how the characters themselves grow attached to one another beyond merely sharing the same goal to save their homes.

5. Game Design

As stated earlier in the exploration section of gameplay, the look for it is inspired by games like *Hollow Knight* or *Metroid*. Here's a clip of *Hollow Knight*'s gameplay to get a better idea of what I am describing. *Hollow Knight*'s UI elements are kept to a minimum throughout gameplay so that the focus of the player can be primarily on their playable character and the environment. The *Metroid* part of the exploration inspiration is mostly based on the upgrades to Samus's kit that allow her to unlock new parts of the map to explore (ex: upgraded missiles to

destroy doors). *In Elementum* takes that Metroidvania-esque mechanic and applies the upgrades as split between all seven of the playable characters and their unique exploration actions.

Combat is heavily inspired by both *Expedition 33* and *Child of Light*. UI is heavily based on *Child of Light*'s.



I also have my own concept art that shows *In Elementum*'s take on this look for combat.



The idea behind using this look is to keep consistency between the 2D exploration gameplay and the battle gameplay. If the game's look changed from 2D to 3D, it would feel confusing. Combat itself is turn-based, and the mechanics I described in the gameplay section borrow a lot of ideas from *Expedition 33*. Here's a clip to give a better idea of what I'm imagining for the gameplay. Turn-based gameplay offers plenty of meaningful choices to be made by the player for success. Plus, with it being turn-based, players are able to take their time to make their decision. Only once an enemy has a turn does the player have to focus more as dodging and parrying are vital to keep the party members alive.